

Public Companies: Defense, Drone & Counter-Drone Technology

Major primes through small-cap up-and-comers, segmented by role in the value chain

1. Major Defense Primes (Diversified, Drone Is One Segment)

Large-cap contractors where UAS/counter-UAS is a meaningful but non-exclusive part of a much larger business.

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
Lockheed Martin	LMT	Modular, open-architecture counter-UAS system combining C2, AI detection, and scalable effectors	Analysts see ~27% upside citing program backlog and dividend strength (2026)
RTX	RTX	Coyote counter-UAS interceptor; major sensor/radar footprint in tactical air defense	New SharpSight radar order (2026); UAE co-production term sheet for Coyote systems
Northrop Grumman	NOC	RQ-4 Global Hawk, MQ-4C Triton; XRQ-73 SHEPARD hybrid-electric drone	Began XRQ-73 SHEPARD flight tests in 2026
L3Harris Technologies	LHX	Counter-UAS solutions and autonomous vehicle integration (formed from L3 + Harris merger)	Continued expansion of autonomy and counter-UAS integration contracts
General Dynamics	GD	Diversified defense contractor with unmanned systems exposure via subsidiaries	Participates in unmanned/autonomy programs alongside core shipbuilding and combat systems

2. Pure-Play Military Drone / Loitering Munition Manufacturers

Companies whose core, majority revenue is unmanned aircraft or attritable combat drones for defense customers.

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
AeroVironment	AVAV	Leading pure-play in tactical UAS and loitering munitions: Raven, Puma, Switchblade	\$3.5B in record contract awards; \$500M DoD counter-UAS contract; Switchblade 400 Army prototype deal (2026)
Kratos Defense & Security Solutions	KTOS	XQ-58A Valkyrie attritable combat drone; target/aerial systems	Valkyrie entering Marine Corps production; Airbus partnership for a German Valkyrie variant; backlog over \$2B (2026)

3. Up-and-Coming Small-Cap Drone Plays

Smaller, faster-moving public companies building specific niches: tactical drones, domestic supply chain, or AI-enabled swarming.

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
Red Cat Holdings	RCAT	Tactical drone platforms (Teal, Black Widow) for defense and government customers	Growing backlog amid Pentagon's shift toward small unmanned systems
Ondas Holdings	ONDS	Aegis drone command-and-control platform; American Robotics automation	New strategic partnership with Palantir; announced \$875.8M acquisition of DZYNE Technologies and UK-based Rotron Aero (2026)

Draganfly	DPRO	AI-powered situational awareness drones for public safety and defense	Palladyne AI collaboration for intelligent swarming software; new NDAA-compliant reseller partnership (2025-2026)
Unusual Machines	UMAC	NDAA-compliant, domestically made drone components (motors, ESCs) to displace Chinese supply chain	\$12.8M Pentagon contract (Oct 2025); raised \$150M in March 2026 to scale production
AIRO Group Holdings	AIRO	Diversified drone/aviation group spanning defense, training, and avionics	Recent public listing; expanding defense-sector drone contracts
ZenaTech	ZENA	AI drone-as-a-service (ZenaDrone) with defense-focused autonomy platform	Expanded defense presence at AUVSI Xponential 2026
Duke Robotics	DUKR	Robotics and drone-based defense/civilian solutions; Bird of Prey defense drone	Collaboration with Elbit Systems on Bird of Prey; recent Nasdaq uplisting (2026)
VisionWave Holdings	WVAV	Vertically integrated autonomous defense platform: ARGUS AI counter-drone, VARAN unmanned ground vehicle	Positioned directly against Pentagon procurement categories in the 2026 Drone Dominance Program

4. Counter-Drone / Anti-UAS Specialists

Companies purpose-built around detecting, tracking, and neutralizing hostile drones -- the fastest-growing niche in defense per 2026 coverage.

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
DroneShield	ASX: DRO / OTC: DRSH F	Only pure-play publicly traded counter-drone company; detection, jamming, and C2 (RfPatrol, DroneGun, DroneSentry)	Revenue surged 121-276% depending on period reported; first year of sustained profitability; A\$1.2B European pipeline (2026)
Axon Enterprise	AXON	Entered airspace security/drone detection via 2024 acquisition of Dedrone	Integrating drone detection with existing law-enforcement platform; partnering with Skydio on "Drone as First Responder"
ParaZero Technologies	PRZO	DefendAir multi-layered, soft-kill counter-UAS systems	Multiple follow-on orders from Israeli defense entity through 2026; showcased at Enforce Tac 2026

5. AI, Software & Autonomy Layer

Companies providing the targeting, coordination, and battle-management software that ties drone hardware into a usable system.

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
Palantir Technologies	PLTR	Maven Smart System and TITAN targeting platform embedded in Pentagon drone/targeting kill chains	\$1.63B Q1 2026 revenue, US business more than doubled YoY; new strategic partnership with Ondas on drone/robotics AI

Notable Private Companies Shaping the Category (Not Directly Investable)

- **Anduril Industries** — Lattice OS, Anvil interceptor, Roadrunner autonomous air vehicle; hired Rocket Lab for hypersonics work; frequently cited as a leading 2026-2027 defense-tech IPO candidate.
- **Shield AI** and **Skydio** — autonomy software and drone hardware respectively; both also cited as IPO candidates, with Skydio landing NATO contracts.
- **Epirus** — Leonidas high-power microwave counter-drone system (defeats swarms via electromagnetic pulse rather than kinetic interceptors); IFPC-HPM Gen II under test at China Lake through 2026.

Category Worth Adding: Supply Chain / Rare Earth & Component Inputs

A structural theme across 2026 coverage is the push to eliminate Chinese-origin components (motors, ESCs, magnets) from U.S. drone supply chains, driven by NDAA Section 1709 and new 2027 procurement rules. Beyond Unusual Machines (above), companies building domestic rare-earth/magnet supply chains for drone propulsion (e.g. REalloys) and Karman Space & Defense (propulsion, payload protection, missile hardware) sit upstream of the drone makers and may be worth a dedicated line if you want full supply-chain coverage, similar to the materials category flagged in the robotics list.

Generated July 10, 2026. This is a disjoint reference set, not a ranked or filtered list.